

COLLISION COURSE

MASS EXTINCTION

When an 8-mile (13-km) wide asteroid crashed into Earth 66 million years ago, it left behind a 112-mile (180-km) wide crater, scarring the planet's crust. This impact caused one of the largest known mass extinctions, bringing the Cretaceous Period to an end as a wide range of species, including all the nonbird dinosaurs, disappeared from the face of the Earth. The asteroid landed in a shallow sea and caused a tsunami with waves 984 ft (300 m) high that devastated low-lying regions. The dust and gases that were released into the atmosphere after the impact blocked out the Sun, causing the planet to cool down, which in turn led to the collapse of ecosystems on land and in the seas.

The outer layers of the asteroid produced a fiery glow as they burned up. The asteroid was traveling at a speed of 12 miles per second (20 km per second) when it entered Earth's atmosphere.

